

Response to Ooi

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Daryl Ooi's nice paper clearly articulates an approach to Wang Yangming's doctrine of the unity of knowledge and action that is implicitly popular but has not to my knowledge been laid out clearly in print before. The key idea is that, for Wang, the kind of knowledge relevant to the unity of knowledge and action, genuine knowledge (*zhen zhi* 真知, Ooi's "Genuine Knowing"), is multifaceted, including diverse forms of knowledge that we would distinguish today (in particular: objectual knowledge, knowledge-how, knowledge-to, and knowledge-that). In different contexts, when faced with different opponents, Wang pragmatically appeals to these different forms of knowledge and, according to Ooi, connects them to the doctrine of the unity of knowledge and action. On Ooi's interpretation, the unity of knowledge and action concerns all of these forms of knowledge, bundled together, along with the diverse ways in which they are related to action. Ooi calls this the "kaleidoscope" model.

In a series of papers that Ooi generously engages with here, I argued that Wang understands genuine knowledge only as objectual knowledge (Lederman 2022a,b, 2023, Manuscript). Ooi and my two headline theses might make it seem that our central point of disagreement concerns whether genuine knowledge is solely objectual or whether it also includes the other forms of knowledge Ooi identifies. But I think a better way to frame the dispute is as one about textual labeling: it is a debate over which passages should be understood to be discussing genuine knowledge. I take a very restrictive view of the matter (see Lederman 2022a, footnotes 10, 11, 12, and main text there). In particular, I hold that only passages with (a) explicit uses of the phrase "genuine knowledge" (*zhen zhi* 真知) or (b) uses of the phrase "extending knowledge" or "extended knowledge" (*zhi zhi* 致知)—*when they are connected explicitly to the unity of knowledge and action*—count as passages in which Wang discusses genuine knowledge. Ooi's arguments against my interpretation rest almost exclusively on passages that fall outside this restricted target. In fact, I am happy to concede (at least for present purposes) that many of the passages he cites discuss

non-objectual knowledge. But I deny that they discuss genuine knowledge. In short, our debate comes down to: How should we demarcate when Wang is discussing “genuine knowledge”?

This is a challenging question, which I struggled with a great deal in writing my own papers. Indeed, the objection that gives me most pause about my own interpretation concerns precisely this issue. This objection (which is a bit different from Ooi’s) is that Wang just doesn’t care about genuine knowledge as a technical term. According to the objection, his uses of this expression are just a throwaway, and there isn’t a unified concept of “genuine knowledge” across the corpus. In support of this objection, it can be noted that the actual phrase “genuine knowledge” occurs most clearly *only* four times in connection to the unity of knowledge and action in the corpus (IPL 5 QJ 4; IPL 5 QJ 5; IPL 125 QJ 42; IPL 133 QJ 47–48; see Lederman 2022a, footnote 10, for more discussion).¹ When we add my uses of “extended knowledge, when it is connected to the unity of knowledge and action,” the sum total of relevant passages only rises to around ten (depending on how strictly we count). If this was a central concept in Wang’s key doctrine of the unity of knowledge and action (the objection continues), it is odd that Wang spoke so little about it. Perhaps even more worrying than his silence on the topic, which could be due to selection among the conversations reported: genuine knowledge does not seem to have been a central topic of discussion among his students.

This objection is very different from various more high-flying objections which have received more attention in the literature (Ivanhoe 2022; Angle Forthcoming; though Cheng [2024, 181–182n17] states the objection with admirable clarity). But it is, as I have said, the one that worries me the most.

My response to this objection is, first, to observe that Wang himself distinguished two components of the doctrine of the unity of knowledge and action, and, second, to acknowledge that later in Wang’s life this doctrine came to play a less central role than it did earlier. On the first point, Wang clearly distinguishes in several places between a version of the doctrine directed at “training” (*gong fu* 工夫) and a version of the doctrine directed at “original natural condition” (*ben ti* 本體) (Lederman 2022b). The key target of my interpretation of genuine knowledge is the latter of these—a doctrine about the epistemology and metaphysics of genuine knowledge. Everyone should agree that this *ben ti* component of the doctrine receives less attention in the corpus than the training component. Correspondingly, we should not be surprised that “genuine knowledge” gets so little play. On the second point, about Wang’s later work, it is clear that Wang began to downplay the term “unity of knowledge and action,” in favor of other slogans like the extension of *zhi liang zhi* (致良知) in his later writings. Given this shift of emphasis, it is not so surprising that the point did not receive sustained discussion by him or his students.

¹IPL refers to Chan 1963; QJ refers to Wu et al. 2011.

Reading all this, one might think: Why on earth would you write three long papers centered on an interpretation of an expression discussed about ten times total in the corpus? Partly, the answer to this is just that I found it interesting, and some readers have agreed that it is. Partly, the answer is that I believe the ideas in my interpretation—and in particular the claims about the metaphysics of genuine knowledge that I described—remained important to Wang throughout his career, especially in his thinking about how extended *liangzhi* was able to guarantee virtuous action. So, even if my interpretation had limited textual scope, I hoped that it ended by elucidating a persistently important element of Wang's thinking.

In short: I'm convinced that Wang *does* use "genuine knowledge" as a technical term in his discussions of the unity of knowledge and action. The move to also consider uses of "extended knowledge" which are explicitly connected to the unity of knowledge and action as cases of "genuine knowledge" was, I thought, a very conservative move from the perspective of arguing that there was a technical notion here. But even then, I recognize that a reasonable and important objection is that even this conservative move may have gone too far.

I've taken the time to say all this here because Ooi's interpretation relies on a much more expansive understanding of which texts discuss genuine knowledge than mine. So, if someone was worried about *my* focus on this technical term, I think they should be at least as worried about Ooi's. Ooi does offer an interesting defense of his expansive understanding of genuine knowledge. He argues that we should individuate Wang's doctrines on the basis of the diseases those doctrines aim to cure, and that the unity of knowledge and action focuses on four different kinds of diseases. He seems to suggest that, although there are four different diseases, because there is one doctrine of the unity of knowledge and action, we should expect that there is one category of knowledge that is working in all of them (i.e., genuine knowledge). We can characterize the passages relevant to genuine knowledge as something like "any case where Wang talks about an elevated form of knowledge which addresses one of the diseases targeted at some point by the unity of knowledge and action." It's just that, since there are four different diseases, we should expect that Wang will invoke four different types of elevated knowledge to address them—that is, that there will be four different types of genuine knowledge.

This is an interesting way of proceeding, but I did wonder if it made sense on its own terms. If there are four different types of diseases, why think that there will be one type of knowledge (genuine knowledge) that covers all of them? At the end of section 4 of his paper, Ooi does consider the possibility of taking a "thin" view of genuine knowledge in his sense, on which the notion would be simply a label, not an underlying category. The only problem is that if one takes this view it becomes unclear whether Ooi and I disagree at all. Ooi would be theorizing a broader category of uses of knowledge which are only "thinly" connected; I would be focusing

on a specific subclass of those uses. Ooi seems to think that my subclass of uses isn't particularly special or interesting, but he doesn't say so explicitly or give a direct argument for this claim. He argues for a "kaleidoscope" view of the passages he groups together, but for present purposes I could concede that (while noting that it's not that surprising that putting many diverse passages together results in a "kaleidoscope view").

Ooi is completely correct that Wang often talks about improving one's knowledge in contexts other than the ones I held to be discussing genuine knowledge. But, as I've said, these passages fall outside of my target. In these other passages Wang either doesn't talk about the unity of knowledge and action (e.g., Ooi's [T6–8], [T12], [T14–17] are all just on a different topic) or he is talking (in my view) about the "training" *gong fu* part of the doctrine ([T9]).

To sum up this discussion: we have two different ways of deciding whether passages discuss "genuine knowledge," my restrictive one and Ooi's expansive one. The restrictive one favors objectual knowledge, and the expansive one favors the kaleidoscope model (or anyway, so far, I've been conceding that). I've argued that there's a much stronger case that the texts captured by my very conservative criterion are unified (as I've admitted, however, one could even raise reasonable concerns about that). By contrast, I don't see strong evidence that Ooi's target is unified. In fact, his own "disease" criterion seems to suggest that they aren't.

That's my first concern about Ooi's interpretation: the text doesn't support the claim that his interpretative target is a unified concept for Wang. A second, weaker concern (which has three parts) comes from Ooi's methodology of starting from the diseases Wang seeks to cure. First, Wang himself does not explicitly draw this fourfold distinction among diseases. If Ooi is right and this fourfold distinction was central to Wang's thinking, then why doesn't Wang talk about it in these terms? Second, if there are four different diseases corresponding to the four different types of knowledge at issue, then why doesn't Wang describe four different doctrines, rather than one doctrine of the unity of knowledge and action? Third and finally, how does this fourfold distinction relate to a distinction Wang *does* talk about (as mentioned above): the distinction between training *gong fu* and original natural condition *ben ti*? To the extent that Ooi's interpretation doesn't make use of this last distinction, and instead makes use of distinctions Wang doesn't draw, it seems to depart from Wang's original ideas.

Those first two concerns are textual. A third objection to Ooi's account (or really a reason to favor mine) has to do with, in my view, an important conceptual payoff of my interpretation. My interpretation explains how Wang could have seen a connection between knowledge and action in their original natural condition *ben ti*, of the astonishingly strong form that I believe he did (as elucidated in Lederman 2022b)—namely, that whenever a person has genuine knowledge they are acting virtuously, and whenever they are acting virtuously they have genuine knowledge. My

interpretation shows how Wang achieved this without trivializing the notion of knowledge (i.e., without simply stipulating that it is equivalent to virtuous action).

Ooi's interpretation doesn't have this payoff. According to him, we can have genuine knowledge of objects (pain), genuine knowledge-how (how to ride a horse), genuine knowledge-to (to be filial), and genuine knowledge-that (of such and such a doctrine). All of these would be unified with action in very different ways. The first requires experience, the second requires sensitivity to circumstance, and the third and fourth require acting correctly. A first point is that the difference in all of these connections to action deepens the problem I mentioned above, of why Wang didn't *say* they were four different doctrines. They do seem quite different! But let's set that aside, and grant for the moment that the first and second connections between knowledge and action make sense. The problem is that it is unclear how to make sense of the third and fourth putative connections to action. Why would genuine knowing-to require acting, other than by stipulation? Why would genuine knowing-that require acting, other than by stipulation? Wang seems to think that the elimination of selfish desires will help, but Ooi's discussion doesn't explain why. Mine does, and I think that's an important advantage.

Ooi talks about an objection in the area of this third one, when he mentions the contrast in abductive power between my view and his, noting that my interpretation is in some sense stronger. But the point here is not so much about strength, but about charity, that an interpretation is better, other things equal, to the extent that it answers questions that the thinker we're interpreting clearly considered and was pushed on by his interlocutors. Ooi's view presents a Wang who is jumping around, doesn't clearly recognize the very different concepts he's invoking, and doesn't face down the problem of the connection between knowledge and action. Mine presents a Wang who isn't confused and in fact addresses this problem clearly. Since many of Wang's interlocutors asked him directly about this issue, I think that makes my interpretation stronger.

Ooi seems inclined to respond by saying that his interpretation allows us to make sense of Wang's method for treating the diseases. But my interpretation does too. On my interpretation, the diseases aren't cured by genuine knowledge—but that's completely consistent with Wang aiming to treat those diseases in other ways. And, as I suggested earlier, it seems more in line with the texts.

My fourth and final objection to the kaleidoscope model concerns what it says about the possession of genuine knowledge. The most natural way of understanding the model is as saying that people can have genuine knowledge of how to ride a horse while lacking genuine knowledge of filial piety. More generally, the whole point of the kaleidoscope model seems to be that these different types of genuine knowledge are separable from one another.

If they are, however, then we can have some strange situations. Could we have one but not all of the colors of the kaleidoscope realized toward relevantly similar objects? For instance, could we have genuine knowledge of filial piety without having genuine knowledge to be filial or how to be filial? I think the most natural conceptual answer for the kaleidoscope model would be “yes,” because after all these are different forms of knowledge. The problem is that this answer seems flatly incompatible with what Wang himself would say. It just doesn’t seem that Wang would admit that you could genuinely know filial piety in one way without genuinely knowing it in another. In particular, any such form of genuine knowledge would have to be tightly connected to virtuous action.

Ooi addresses this problem in footnote 46 of his paper, where he suggests a way of rejecting this concerning consequence of the kaleidoscope model. In particular, he discusses the doctrine of “Relevant-Thing Dependence: To have Genuine Knowing of a thing, one must know the thing in the relevant sense.” The idea is that the *object* of knowledge specifies what the relevant form of genuine knowledge is. So far, this doctrine on its own doesn’t eliminate the problem: there’s piety and there’s acting piously. Those *different* objects should have different forms of genuine knowledge, and we’re back in trouble.

But at the close of the footnote, Ooi suggests that “To Genuinely Know filiality, one must have an inclination to be filial (know-to).” This idea was quite interesting to me, but I also found it confusing. It looks like Ooi is saying that genuine objectual knowledge of filiality (note the syntax on the left-hand side) requires knowing-to. Perhaps he is saying that there is one generic category, filiality (covering all of objectual, action, and so on), which has just one form of genuine knowledge corresponding to it—namely, knowing-to. (So there is not really genuine objectual knowledge of filial piety.) Presumably the same could be said about brotherly respect, loyalty, and all the other virtues.

This new doctrine does solve the problem. But it is an abandonment of the kaleidoscope model altogether. It is a doctrine that says that the most important form of genuine knowledge—the one connected to the virtues—is ultimately knowing-to! That is not a kaleidoscope model; it is what I called the “practical” model of genuine knowledge.

A different response that might seem to solve the problem would be to stipulate that all the forms of genuine knowledge just go together: genuine objectual knowledge of filial piety comes together with genuine knowledge-to of filial piety and so on. But this is also an abandonment of the kaleidoscope model, or at least an admission that it is nowhere near the whole story. For it would seem to require a much thicker background notion of genuine knowledge that would explain why genuine knowledge of one type toward filial piety guarantees genuine knowledge of another type.

So we are left with a problem: either abandon the kaleidoscope model or allow that this model implies that the different forms of genuine knowledge are separable. The latter conclusion should be no more acceptable for fans of the kaleidoscope model than the former. Everyone should agree that Wang himself would not have wanted one form of genuine knowledge connected to filiality to be present (say, objectual knowledge of filial piety) while another was absent (say, genuine knowledge of how to be filial).

In the final section, Ooi makes a revealing comment, which suggests that he is, in a way, sensitive to this concern. He writes:

Genuine Knowing therefore should not be reduced or constrained to a single conception of knowing. Rather, it involves skillfully recognizing which kinds of knowing are relevant for which kinds of object of knowledge, and applying the correct kind of knowing to that object.

In this passage, Ooi understands genuine knowledge not as whichever type of knowledge of the relevant kind (viz., objectual, knowledge-how, knowledge-to, or knowledge-that) meets some conditions but instead as meta-knowledge, a skill of toggling between these different sorts of base-level knowledge. This later comment represents a *very* different view than the kaleidoscope approach as I had understood it throughout the paper (and certainly doesn't allow the sort of separability I mentioned before).

In making this comment, I think Ooi does us an important service. I suspect that scholars who will be and have been attracted to something like the "kaleidoscope model" typically *do* run together these two different sorts of ideas. On the one hand, they have a very rich understanding of genuine knowledge as a cognitive ability in the background (similar to what Ooi says in the quote). But, when pressed, they tend to revert to a very thin (and very different) version of the doctrine, more similar to the kaleidoscope model as Ooi presents it in most of the paper. Ooi has brought out this tension in his paper very clearly.

To wrap up: my first concern about Ooi's approach is textual. Wang doesn't use the term "genuine knowledge" very much at all. Many of the passages that Ooi uses to argue for his view are ones in which Wang is not talking about the unity of knowledge and action, and it's not clear to me what the value is of seeing these as discussions of genuine knowledge in particular. (As I've said, my main concern about my own approach is that it already went too far on this front, but Ooi is going *much* farther.) I think there isn't strong evidence that there's a unified subject matter in the passages Ooi brings together. Ooi says we could adopt a "thin approach" that makes sense of this, but a better approach might be to either restrict the use of the term (as I did) or abandon it. It's not surprising that if we pull together diverse passages that do quite different things, then

the best interpretation of them would be as a “kaleidoscope.”

My second concern was also textual. It had three parts. First, Wang doesn’t draw the fourfold distinction Ooi draws among diseases explicitly. Second, if Ooi is right about Wang’s fourfold distinction, then it’s surprising that Wang considers his doctrine just one doctrine, and not four. This second subproblem is deepened by the fact that the different notions of knowledge would have to be connected to action in conceptually very different ways. Third, Ooi’s interpretation doesn’t fit naturally with the training/original natural condition distinction that Wang clearly *does* draw.

My third concern was conceptual. Ooi’s way of demarcating the concept of genuine knowledge doesn’t give us the conceptual payoff, in terms of charity, that mine did. My approach helps us to understand what I see as a central question—namely, what Wang thought underwrote the connection between genuine knowledge and action. My interpretation has a rich story here. Ooi’s does not.

Fourth and finally, Ooi’s kaleidoscope model seems to allow possibilities that Wang himself would have denied (e.g., that we can have genuine knowledge of filial piety without genuinely knowing how to be filially pious). Or, better, there’s a dilemma here: Either there are deep connections between the kaleidoscope’s various colors, which the account has yet to explain (and which I think would amount to giving up its “thin” approach), or the account allows possibilities that Wang would have denied. In either case, it doesn’t seem right.

Ooi emphasizes a tradeoff between strength and accuracy in our two different approaches. I think we don’t have to go to this meta-level to see the tradeoffs between his approach and mine, as I’ve illustrated here. It’s true that there are some passages that don’t look perfect on my interpretation. But I think Ooi’s interpretation has different and deeper sorts of problems.

My own view about writing on methodology is that it is overrated. Methodological reflections (and I include my own 2024 here) are typically too abstract to be useful in practice. We should do less talking about methodology and more serious work on interpreting the text. We should do more of doing our best to produce interpretations of the texts which make sense of their authors’ words and ideas in the context of everything we know about them. There are always barriers to understanding based on differences in culture and the passage of time, but I tend to think that our discipline has over-emphasized these barriers, with the effect (or even aim) of exoticizing thinkers like Wang into a realm of inexplicable mysticism, rather than taking them seriously as serious people who were doing their best to understand deep questions about the nature of knowledge and virtue, and how to live well in light of the answers they found. Ooi has done us a service by giving the kaleidoscope model the best run it could get. But I remain convinced that it does not

stand up to the texts as the right story about what Wang thought.

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